

Mail

which can't be isolated from various social, religious, economic and political problems plaguing the country. Our leaders need to face reality to initiate radical administrative and electoral reforms in the country for it to acquire the will to act, certainly in the areas where questions of national security and survival are involved. Anything less would invite a bigger disaster.
DR VITULL K. GUPTA,
via www.indiatoday.in

House on Hold

At a time when our elected representatives must coalesce their collective wisdom to evolve ways to meet the perils of terrorism, internal insurgency and economic meltdown, their declining participation in the proceedings of the House and quality of debate in Parliament is worrisome ("An Uncommon House", January 19). Dearth of well-informed candidates to choose from and non-involvement of a large number of voters in the election process is to be blamed for this impasse.

Y.G. CHOUKSEY,
via www.indiatoday.in

The not so exemplary manner in which our honourable members of Parliament (MPs) conduct themselves on the floor of the House reveals their disdain. They tend to show solidarity on only two counts—perks and

privileges—but care two hoots about their duties and responsibilities. To protect democratic decay, the Election Commission should bar erring MPs who fail to attend the proceedings and instead indulge in creating unruly scenes and abstain from participating in debates and raising questions, from contesting elections.
K.R.P. GUPTA,
via www.indiatoday.in

Friends of Foes

After showing its magna-

however, can draw solace from the fact that it didn't enter into any coalition with the PDP. To restore people's faith, the party needs to try and undo the bad track record of its alliances with the NC.
S. LAKSHMI,
via www.indiatoday.in

Best at Worst

Thanks to better fiscal management, we did not have to suffer some of the serious effects of the global meltdown ("Agony of Ecstasy",



“Slumdog Millionaire has done India proud. The four Golden Globe awards for Danny Boyle's film reflect the acceptance of Bollywood by Hollywood. Good show, India.”

V.K. TANGRI, *via www.indiatoday.in*

nimity by giving the required numbers to the National Conference (NC) for the coalition government in Jammu and Kashmir, the Congress is at a point of no return ("Abdullah The Third", January 5). Its complacency will reflect its concern for a stable government. The party,

January 5). However, the growth rate has come down considerably and would continue to be low till year-end. This is the time for fiscal prudence and consolidation rather than wasteful spending and unbridled expansion.
D.B.N. MURTHY,
via www.indiatoday.in

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30
 YEARS
 AGO IN
 INDIA
 TODAY

MARCH 1-15, 1979

Boom State

The land lies verdant under the winter sun. Green and gold mustard fields stretch lushly on either side of the Grand Trunk Road. Under a clear blue sky, a robust young farmer steers his tractor through the rolling acres, his bright pink turban flashing defiantly. In a cluster of solid brick houses, village women sit lazily in courtyards tuning in transistors while awaiting their turns at churning milk. A chattering stream of healthy children trickles out to roast happily under the sun in the playfields. The scenario is unusual if not actually Utopian in the Indian context. Peace, prosperity and three decades of unfaltering progress have transformed Punjab into India's boom state, a model of success so far removed from the rest of the country that planners are forced to recognise it as an "island of prosperity in a sea of poverty." But 30 years ago, the same landscape lay shattered.

Sunil Sethi and Prabhu Chawla

